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SOC 4322 01
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Interview Project Part 1: Ideas Paragraph

For this project, I am interested in exploring the **intersection of cultural class/capital and romantic relationships**. While economic stratification is often measured by income, cultural class involves the lifestyle, tastes, and social signals that define one's position in the social hierarchy. I am interested in how these cultural markers act as "gatekeepers" in dating and marriage, effectively narrowing the pool of potential partners to those with similar backgrounds. This topic is sociologically significant because romantic choices are a primary way social stratification is perpetuated; by marrying within one's cultural class, individuals consolidate social, cultural, and economic capital, making social mobility more difficult for those outside these circles. I want to move beyond mere "fact-finding" and actually analyze the personal experiences, reactions, and feelings of my interviewee regarding their romantic preferences and perceived class boundaries.

To explore this, I plan to interview "Brad" who is a local professor in the Waco community. "Brad" is an ideal candidate for my topic because they have navigated different social environments throughout their career and can speak to how their professional and cultural status has influenced their social circles and romantic history. I have confirmed that this person is not a close acquaintance, friend, or family member. I intend to conduct this 30-minute interview at a quiet, local coffee shop to ensure a safe and convenient environment for "Brad."

My primary goal is to understand the "unwritten rules" that "Brad" perceives in the dating world. I am interested in their views and feelings on what makes a partner "compatible" from a class perspective. I want to ask questions such as: "Have you ever felt a 'cultural gap' with someone you were dating, even if they had a similar income?" and "How do you feel your educational background shapes who you are attracted to?" In listening to specific expressions or "striking ways" which "Brad" describes these boundaries, I will gather qualitative data that illustrates how personal romantic feelings are deeply connected to the larger structures of social stratification. This will eventually help me connect "Brad's" individual story to broader course themes regarding how inequality is maintained through romantic-social interactions and courtships/marriages.

This project will allow me to apply course concepts like **cultural capital** and **assortative mating** to a real-world narrative. By focusing on "Brad's" story, I aim to provide a descriptive, focused, sociological analysis of how "cultural class" preferences perpetuate stratification. Analyzing "Brad's" subjective feelings will reveal how individual romantic choices reinforce broader structures of inequality.

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Ideas

For this “Stratification” project, I would like to further explore **corporate exploitation of low-income communities** (Healthcare, Data/AI centers, etc.).

How **cultural class shapes not only dating/marriage** experiences and preferences, **but also perpetuates social stratification:**
